

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Baristas and Cafe Staff English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Baristas, cafe counter staff, and coffee pickup staff.

All orders, prices, recipes, promotions, and incidents are fictional language practice, not barista certification, allergen-control training, health advice, or equipment-maintenance instruction. Recipes and terminology vary by cafe. Use current workplace information and refer suitability or equipment questions to the designated lead. This course focuses on counter and coffee-bar exchanges, not hospitality management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

Americano

An espresso drink diluted with water according to the cafe's recipe.

cappuccino

An espresso-and-milk drink typically featuring a noticeable foam layer; recipes vary.

cash float

The starting cash kept in a till to provide change.

combo

A stated combination of items offered together at a listed price.

cup label

The printed or written drink information attached to a cup.

decaf

Coffee from which most caffeine has been removed; it is not necessarily caffeine-free.

dine in

An order intended to be consumed in the cafe rather than taken away.

espresso

A concentrated coffee drink prepared by passing hot water through finely ground coffee under pressure.

filter coffee

Coffee brewed by passing water through ground coffee and a filter.

grind size

The relative coarseness or fineness of ground coffee.

latte

An espresso drink with milk; proportions and serving styles vary by cafe.

loyalty reward

A benefit available under a cafe's stated customer-reward conditions.

milk alternative

A plant-based drink offered instead of dairy milk, with ingredients varying by product.

mobile order

An order placed through a phone app or similar online ordering service.

order modifier

A detail changing a drink's standard size, ingredient, or service choice.

order queue

The sequence of orders waiting for preparation or completion.

order ticket

A printed or electronic record connecting a cafe order to its specifications and identifier.

pickup name

The name used to identify a completed order at the collection point.

reconciliation

A comparison of recorded transactions with counted money or other relevant records to identify differences.

remake

A replacement drink made again to correct an order or preparation problem.

roast date

The date shown for when coffee was roasted, not when the package was purchased.

shared equipment

Equipment used for more than one product, relevant to questions about possible allergen cross-contact.

shot

A cafe's specified serving of espresso; exact size and recipe vary.

sold out

No longer available for purchase because the available stock has been used or sold.

stockout

A situation in which a needed product or supply is unavailable.

sweetened

Containing added sweetening ingredients; the description may apply to a component or finished drink.

syrup

A flavored liquid sweetener used in some cafe drinks.

tasting notes

Descriptors suggesting a coffee's perceived flavors, not necessarily added ingredients.

texture

The way a drink feels in the mouth, such as smooth or foamy, as described by the customer.

till

The cafe's sales register or the cash drawer associated with it.

upcharge

An additional price for a specified change or extra item.

whole bean

Coffee sold as intact roasted beans rather than already ground.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Unpack the word 'regular'

By regular, do you mean ___?

Would you like that hot or ___?

That's a ___ latte with ___, for ___.

Ask one specification at a time. Decaf describes coffee, not milk or sweetness, and doesn't mean guaranteed zero caffeine.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm the drink size: check the selected menu size

make it decaf: request the cafe's decaffeinated coffee option

leave room: request space below the top of a filled cup

repeat the full drink: check type, size, temperature style, and changes together

Compare the criterion the customer cares about

Both use ___, but ___ has more ___.

When you say strong, are you asking about ___?

For your preference for ___, ___ may suit you.

Ask whether 'strong' means coffee flavor, less milk, or caffeine. Local recipe facts support a comparison; they don't establish precise caffeine totals.

Word combinations in this lesson

describe the milk balance: explain how milky an option tastes

compare the menu recipes: use this cafe's actual drink descriptions

offer a flavor description: describe taste without promising a personal reaction

avoid a caffeine guarantee: do not infer exact caffeine content from taste or color

A modification doesn't settle every concern

Do you mean no syrup, or ___?

I can confirm ___ is available, but not yet ___.

Let me ask the lead about ___.

No syrup doesn't necessarily mean no added sweetener in other ingredients. A plant-based name doesn't resolve all ingredient or cross-contact questions.

Word combinations in this lesson

omit the syrup: leave out the flavored sweetener

check the carton: consult the actual product's current ingredient information

relay a milk-allergy concern: pass on the customer's stated allergy accurately

separate two requests: distinguish less sweetness from avoidance of an ingredient

Identify the order before handing it over

Which ticket number are you collecting?

This is ___; your order is ___.

___ is complete, while ___ is in progress.

A pickup name may not be unique. Check drink specifications or the ticket number without requesting unrelated personal details.

Word combinations in this lesson

match the ticket number: compare the order identifier before collection

call the pickup name: announce the name linked to the completed order

check an order's status: find whether it is received, in progress, or complete

keep a grouped order together: connect drinks belonging to the same order

Fix the specification before the remake

The ticket says ___; the label says ___.

Would you still like ___?

I'll check the remake time before ___.

Distinguish an incorrect label from a verified ingredient claim. The correct ticket supplies the requested drink, while the bar checks what happened.

Word combinations in this lesson

acknowledge a mismatch: name the difference between the order and the drink

check the cup label: compare the written specification with the ticket

request a fresh remake: ask for a new drink with confirmed details

describe the customer's concern: repeat the issue without guessing its cause

Clarify the brewer before changing the beans

What kind of brewer do they use?

Would you prefer to leave the beans ___?

That phrase describes flavor, not ___.

A tasting note doesn't prove an ingredient is present or absent. Ask about the brewer; don't prescribe an unsupported grind when the equipment is unknown.

Word combinations in this lesson

ask about the brewer: identify the customer's coffee-making equipment

leave the beans whole: sell the coffee without grinding it

read the tasting notes: explain the package's flavor descriptions

confirm before grinding: check the chosen product and intended brewer before an irreversible change

Explain the complete offer

The combo includes ___ at ___.

The ___ upcharge still applies, making ___.

Separately, the same items total ___.

An offer name doesn't specify every condition. Explain this fictional cafe's prices without implying all cafes charge the same way.

Word combinations in this lesson

quote the full drink price: state the price including selected changes

apply an eligible reward: use a benefit only when its stated conditions are met

offer the remaining choice: explain an available alternative to a sold-out item

separate item and offer prices: distinguish an individual price from a combination deal

Transfer three different statuses

___ is complete; ___ remains on the queue.

We're out of ___, not ___.

I've counted ___; ___ is still pending.

Counting cash is not the same as reconciling it with records. Explain the specific stockout so the next worker doesn't assume every size is unavailable.

Word combinations in this lesson

hand over the order queue: explain unfinished orders to the incoming barista

count the float: check the starting change cash without assuming sales totals

flag a till discrepancy: report a difference between the count and the record

report a stockout: name the exact unavailable product or supply

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Taking a precise drink order

A customer says 'a regular latte.' This cafe uses regular for its middle size, but the customer might mean caffeinated coffee or the usual milk. No drink has been made. Clarify size, hot or iced, and coffee choice separately.

When you say regular, do you mean our middle size or caffeinated coffee? I'll check those separately so I enter the right drink. Would you like the latte hot or iced, and which milk would you prefer? Once those details are clear, I'll repeat the full order before sending it to the bar.

Try it again: The customer says 'the normal one' about milk. Ask for the actual milk choice.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Comparing drinks without overclaiming

In this fictional cafe, the small latte and small cappuccino both contain the same espresso serving. The cappuccino has more foam; the latte has more liquid milk. The customer wants less foam, not more caffeine. Compare the two using those facts.

In our small drinks, both choices use the same espresso serving. The cappuccino has more foam, while the latte has more liquid milk. Since you're asking for less foam rather than more coffee, the latte sounds closer to that preference. I wouldn't use how strong it tastes as an exact measure of caffeine.

Try it again: The customer asks whether a stronger taste guarantees more caffeine. Explain the limit.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Clarifying milk, syrup, and allergy questions

A customer reports a milk allergy and asks for an oat latte without vanilla syrup. The barista knows oat drink is available but has not checked its current ingredients or shared-equipment arrangements. No claim of suitability can be made from the drink name.

I can note oat drink and no vanilla syrup, but those changes don't by themselves establish suitability for your milk allergy. I need to check the current product information and ask our lead about shared equipment. Let's leave the drink unmade while we get those details, so you can decide with accurate information.

Try it again: A colleague says plant-based always means suitable. Explain what that label doesn't establish.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Managing the queue and pickup

Two customers named Sam have orders. Ticket 64 is a small hot latte and is complete. Ticket 67 is a large iced decaf latte and is in progress. The customer collecting 67 hears 'Sam' and reaches for 64. Clarify using ticket and drink details.

Are you collecting ticket sixty-seven, the large iced decaf latte? This completed drink is a small hot latte on sixty-four for another Sam. Your order is still in progress. I'll use the ticket number as well as the name when I call it, so the two orders don't get mixed up.

Try it again: The label is partly hidden. Check the ticket rather than guessing from the name.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Handling remakes and mistaken labels

Ticket 22 requests a small iced latte with no syrup, but the cup label says hot vanilla latte. The customer hasn't collected it. A replacement is available; its wait hasn't been checked. Correct the mismatch without claiming a refund or a serving time.

The cup label doesn't match your ticket: you ordered a small iced latte with no syrup, but this label says hot vanilla. I'm sorry for that mix-up. I'll request a fresh drink with your confirmed details and check the wait before giving you an estimate. Is the original order still what you'd like?

Try it again: The bar offers a different size. Check whether the customer wants that change rather than assuming.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Discussing coffee beans for home

A customer buys a gift bag and asks for 'normal ground.' They don't know the recipient's brewer. This cafe sells the same coffee whole or ground. Grinding cannot be undone. The package's 'hazelnut' note describes flavor, not an ingredient statement.

Could you tell me what kind of brewer the recipient uses? There isn't one grind described as normal for every brewer, and grinding can't be undone. We can leave this bag whole while you check. Also, the hazelnut tasting note describes a flavor impression; it isn't the ingredient information for an allergy question.

Try it again: The customer asks whether 'hazelnut notes' guarantees an ingredient is absent. Refer to actual product information.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Explaining counter prices and sold-out items

A fictional cafe lists a latte at \$4, an oat-drink upcharge of \$0.50, and a pastry at \$3. The \$6 combo includes a standard latte and pastry; the oat upcharge still applies. Explain \$6.50 for that combo, versus \$7.50 separately, before payment.

The standard latte-and-pastry combo is six dollars. Your oat-drink choice adds fifty cents, so that combination is six fifty. Bought separately, the four-dollar latte, fifty-cent change, and three-dollar pastry would total seven fifty. The combo saves one dollar for these items; shall I enter that option with the oat choice?

Try it again: The selected pastry sells out before payment. Ask whether the customer wants the remaining pastry; don't substitute silently.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Handing over the bar and till

At 2:00, ticket 108's coffee is complete but its tea is pending. Large takeaway lids are unavailable, though small lids remain. The outgoing worker counted the till, but the lead's reconciliation is pending. Assign the tea and stock follow-up without calling the till signed off.

Ticket one-oh-eight still needs its tea; the coffee is complete. Large takeaway lids are out, but small lids remain. Can you take the tea order and confirm the large-lid situation with the lead? I've counted the till, but reconciliation isn't complete. I'll stay responsible for that review until the lead takes it.

Try it again: A coworker says the till 'looks about right.' Keep the unresolved record comparison explicit.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Food and Beverage Serving and Related Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/food-and-beverage-serving-and-related-workers.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Baristas

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-3023.01>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Baristas and Cafe Staff English

Professional audience: Baristas, cafe counter staff, and coffee pickup staff

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Lesson 01: Taking a precise drink order

Original fictional case: A customer says 'a regular latte.' This cafe uses regular for its middle size, but the customer might mean caffeinated coffee or the usual milk. No drink has been made. Clarify size, hot or iced, and coffee choice separately.

Language workshop: Unpack the word 'regular'

Communication goal: Clarify a familiar word that can describe several order details.

Language guidance: Ask one specification at a time. Decaf describes coffee, not milk or sweetness, and doesn't mean guaranteed zero caffeine.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): By regular, do you mean ___? / Would you like that hot or ___? / That's a ___ latte with ___, for ___.

Vocabulary: espresso: A concentrated coffee drink prepared by passing hot water through finely ground coffee under pressure. / shot: A cafe's specified serving of espresso; exact size and recipe vary. / decaf: Coffee from which most caffeine has been removed; it is not necessarily caffeine-free. / dine in: An order intended to be consumed in the cafe rather than taken away.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Customer: you mean middle size; choose hot, decaf, and whole milk when asked.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The customer says 'the normal one' about milk. Ask for the actual milk choice.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: When you say regular, do you mean our middle size or caffeinated coffee? I'll check those separately so I enter the right drink. Would you like the latte hot or iced, and which milk would you prefer? Once those details are clear, I'll repeat the full order before sending it to the bar.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT